Consequences of Group Style for Differential Participation

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Citation: Carlsen, Hjalmar Bang, Jonas Toubøl, and Snorre Ralund. 2020. "Consequences of Group Style for Differential Participation." *Social Forces* Advance online publication. doi:10.1093/sf/soaa063.

Abstract: This article proposes a theory of how interaction in groups influences differential participation in political activism and interrogates this theory through an empirical analysis of online Facebook group interaction. We study the refugee solidarity movement in a mixed methods design employing online ethnography, survey, and "big" social media data. Instead of conceptualizing the group as a social network or social movement organization (SMO), we argue that the group's culture emerges as patterns of interaction that have implications for what kind of activities in which group members participate. Based on observations from our online ethnography, we suggest that group interaction influences differential individual participation through processes of 1) encoding different habits and 2) attuning the activist to different aspects of situations. We support our theoretical propositions with six statistical tests of the relationship between the group-level variable of *contentious group style* and the individual-level variable of participation in *political protest*. The dependent variable, *political protest*, and a comprehensive set of controls stem from an original survey of the Danish refugee solidarity movement with 2,283 respondents. We link the survey data with "big" social media data used to estimate the focal explanatory variable, *contentious group style*, generated from content analysis of online interaction in 119 Facebook groups quantified with supervised machine learning. The results show that group style has a consistently positive relationship with the individual's degree of participation independent of networks, SMO framing, and individual attributes.

Keywords: Differential participation, group interaction, group culture, computational content analysis, mixed methods, political protest, social media, refugee solidarity movement

Acknowledgements: We are grateful to Anders Blok, Nicole Doerr, Nina Eliasoph, Peter Gundelach, Christian Ibsen, Jeffrey S. Juris, Jane Mansbridge, Doug McAdam and Thomas Olesen for their valuable comments along the way.

Funding: Jonas Toubøl's research for this paper was supported by the Carlsberg Foundation as part of the project entitled *Mobilization in the era of social media: Introducing the decisive role of group level factors* (grant number CF17-0199).

1. Introduction

The group is ubiquitous in social movement theory, where individuals come together in groups to protest for social change and ensure public goods. Many seminal small N studies of social movements pay attention to the internal dynamics and processes of groups or social movement organizations (SMO) (e.g., Lichterman 1996; McAdam 1988; Teske 1997; Whittier 1997), and prominent theories stress the importance of groups (e.g., Hirsch 1990; McAdam 1986; Melucci 1989). However, what goes on inside social movement groups and the consequences thereof have not been sufficiently theoretically investigated.

Two conceptions of the group dominate the literature: The first perspective views the group as a network composed of dyadic relations. Here, strength (Passy 2001), salience (McAdam and Paulsen 1993), or some other quality of ties lead to varying levels of participation in different kinds of activism (Hensby 2014; Tindall 2015). The second perspective conceptualizes the group as a social movement organization (SMO). Here the group is viewed as a collective actor that defines itself and its repertoire of action through processes of frame alignment. The focus is on the agency of the group framing itself strategically to advance its goals (Snow et al. 1986; Snow and Benford 1988). As we will argue in depth below, the interactional dynamics within the group setting are not addressed sufficiently by these theories. To fill this gap, a recent wave of studies has taken group interaction as their main concern (Becker 1999; Blee 2012; Eliasoph and Lichterman 2003; Lichterman and Eliasoph 2014). Work within this strand has started to focus on how patterns of interaction influence participation. Andrew J. Perrin argues that "political microcultures," may "explain part of the often-observed differences among civic organizations' degree and type of political mobilization" (Perrin 2005: 1049). Paul Lichterman and Nina Eliasoph (2014) argue that qualitatively different styles of interaction cultivate different skills among participants, which lead to different patterns of individual participation (for a similar argument see Mische 2008). These studies warrant taking 'style' seriously as a mechanism that explains differential participation. Most studies within this strand of work draw primarily on qualitative data, especially ethnographic data. Lichterman and Eliasoph (2014:800-1) argue that there is a need for studies that demonstrate how styles of interaction, in the aggregate, correlate with individual participation patterns beyond the group setting. This paper presents an attempt at such a study.

Expanding on this body of studies, we develop a theory of how patterns of interaction in group settings influence differential participation in collective action. Our theoretical proposition is that group style influences individual participation in the short- and long-term perspectives. In the long-term perspective, the group style encodes certain habits of thought and—in the individual—that shapes future interpretations, actions, and choices. In the short-term perspective, the individual becomes engrossed in the group's flow of interaction that steers the individual's actions. We substantiate these propositions by undertaking a large N study of the consequences of variation in group styles for individual group member participation in political protest. We have surveyed 2,283 activists in the Danish refugee solidarity movement sampled from 119 online Facebook groups, and in parallel, we used supervised machine learning to undertake a large-scale content analysis of all interactions within the groups. We link the two datasets at the group level, allowing us to estimate how patterns of interaction in groups influence individual-level participation recorded in the survey data.

We find that the level of contentiousness in the interactions in the Facebook groups strongly influences the likelihood of the individual participating in political protest, both inside and outside the group. Furthermore, we find that the effect differs with regard to the activist's history of activism, revealing that experienced activists are more resilient to the effects of group style than non-experienced activists. This overall finding supports the study's main theoretical proposition that, alongside the established meso-level factors of network and framing, group style matters for differential participation. In addition to expanding our conceptualization of the group, these findings accentuate the need for methods and data that take within-group interaction into account.

In the following section, we outline our case, the Danish refugee solidarity movement. In section three, we explain the concept of group style and how it distinguishes itself from network and framing, as well as how it influences differential participation. Section four describes the statistical research design that combines survey data and "big" social media data to test the relationship between group interaction and individual participation in political protest. In section five, we present the results, which we discuss in relation to theoretical propositions in section six.

2. The Danish refugee solidarity movement: organization, development, and engagement

Our case is the Danish refugee solidarity movement, which can be dated back to at least the late 1970s. However, we concentrate on the recent mobilization that began in the fall of 2014 in relation to an increasing influx of refugees and took a dramatic turn in September 2015 when the so-called European refugee crisis reached Denmark. Consequently, within weeks, tens of thousands of Danish residents mobilized and organized assistance for the refugees, in effect doubling the number of members of the movement's Facebook groups (Toubøl 2015; 2017). The dynamics of the movement changed with regard to the intensity and urgency of providing for the many refugees, but overall, the repertoire of the movement did not change in the sense that the bulk of activities before and after September 2015 was humanitarian and non-contentious, and political protest, while not rare, was the minor part of the repertoire (Toubøl 2019; Gundelach and Toubøl 2019).

There are two theoretical and one methodological reason for why group style is both an important and measurable phenomenon for explaining individuals' participation in collective action during the recent mobilization of the refugee solidarity movement:

1. The movement mainly consists of relatively small, local, grassroots groups with little if any formal organization. This organizational characteristic makes the analysis of group interaction even more important (Blee 2012) since activities in such settings are not defined by leadership but decided by rank and file.
2. Typical of humanitarian movements (Boltanski 1999; Eliasoph 2013), the major division in the movement is about choosing a contentious or a purely humanitarian and non-contentious strategy. Most groups help refugees with social, cultural, material, and legal issues; however, the question is whether they also engage in political activity such as advocacy and protest on behalf of refugees in an attempt to influence lawmakers and public opinion. Such political and critical engagement can be an official part of the groups' agendas, or it can be something that comes about through interaction within groups, or it can be excluded in the culture of the interaction of groups where a strictly humanitarian approach to the issue is favored, officially or unofficially. The role of contentious talk within groups is vital because, if excluded, contentious action and

political protest may be rarer among the members (Eliasoph and Lichterman 2003). Thus, group culture may be a central determinant of the degree to which activists enter into contention with the proponents of a restrictive immigration policy. Indeed, this hypothetical relationship is the central question of this study.

3. This mobilization happened primarily on and through the social media of Facebook, thus leaving textual traces of group interaction enabling the construction of quantitative measures of group style. In the movement, Facebook groups are used for everything from coordinating political, social, and humanitarian activity to telling stories and interacting with other movement activists. They are the closest we get to a formal frame for the group's activities. Thus, the interactions and activities in the Facebook groups become a central empirical source for analysis of the inner workings of the movement. These rich and quantifiable online data on internal group interaction gives our study a paradigmatic status, granting new opportunities to combine qualitative and quantitative investigation of the consequences of group interaction for individual participation. We use the communication within the Facebook groups to analyze interactional style qualitatively, through in-depth reading, and quantitatively, by coding and scaling with supervised machine learning.

The online ethnography informs the theoretical discussion below and is used to illustrate central points. It was composed of an in-depth study of two Facebook groups, reading a large random sample of posts and comments drawn from across the movement and following the activity and communication of dozens of groups regularly throughout 2015 and 2016. For a deeper understanding of the internal group dynamics, we refer the reader to Appendix 1, which contains a detailed summary of a case analysis of one of the most important groups.

3. The Group Level in Social Movement Theory

In this section, we will put forth the three theoretical arguments that constitute the main contribution of the study. We argue that group interaction should not be conflated with social networks or SMO framing and, furthermore, that group style is an important factor in explaining differential participation in activism. Also, to clarify how group style constitutes a source of differential participation, we compare these processes to the related theories of socialization and identity formation in networks.

Groups have been analyzed with a focus on how processes of SMO framing (Snow and Benford 1988; Snow et al. 1986) and the degree of network embeddedness (Snow, Zurcher, and Ekland-Olson 1980; McAdam and Paulsen 1993; Toubøl and Jensen 2014; Ibsen et al. 2017) influence the individual's participation in different types of activism. These approaches have proved successful in connecting the micro and macro levels (e.g., Hirsch 1990; Taylor and Whittier 1992), but, we will argue, too much uniform agency within the SMO has been assumed, and it is imprecise to conflate the group with the network.

Instead of the network and framing aspect, we focus on the interactional aspect. The interactional aspect is captured by the concept of group style (Eliasoph and Lichterman 2003; Lichterman and Eliasoph 2014), which is the group members' shared understanding of a situation and system of typifications and relevancies (Schutz 1975:82). A group's style captures a group's shared assumptions about what are good and adequate forms of participation in the group setting (Eliasoph

and Lichterman 2003). Eliasoph and Lichterman first developed the concept of group style to understand how culture works in everyday group settings. In later work, they (2014) change their concept to *scene style* in order to handle complex organization, networks, and projects where different styles can be in play at different times and in different settings but in the same group. Although our qualitative analysis and our computational method could capture the shifting scene styles in the groups, the coupling with survey data allows analysis only at an aggregated group level. Therefore, the concept of group style better fits what we can measure.

The empirical expression of a group style is the recurring and relatively stable patterns of interaction. Because group style is the members' shared understanding of a situation, the style is likely to have consequences for what kind of activism members organize and participate in. This is quite different from how networks and SMO framing influence involvement in action, as we will now explain in detail.

Group interaction is not network structure

There are two main differences between a group style and a network perspective. First, the former focuses on the content of interactions in a setting of multiple co-present interacting actors, whereas the latter identifies the structure of the dyadic relationships between group members. Group interaction is focused on actors being co-present, where one's actions are displayed to the group rather than a single relation within the group. Interaction in groups is situational in the Goffmanian sense—happening within an environment where the group can monitor it and where the actor can adjust her behavior to the setting.

Second, the focus on group interaction also foregrounds the patterns of discourse created through interaction. Typically, the content of the relations constituting the ties of a network is black-boxed (Erikson 2013; Mische and White 1998). Although studies have shown the importance of differentiating between weak and strong ties or salience of ties in explaining participation in different forms of activism (e.g., Passy 2001; McAdam and Paulsen 1993), it is equally important to understand what practices those relations are made of, as observers have rightly pointed out (McAdam 2003; Passy and Monsch 2014, 2020). Analysis of group interaction may help open up the black box of group ties by specifying what types of interaction constitute the relationships and how the style of interaction constrains and enables the type of social influence that can flow through the group setting (for a similar point see Lichterman 2006). Later in this paper, we shall discuss in detail how this is different from and supplements network explanations of participation.

Group interaction is not identical to SMO framing

The SMO framing literature is concerned primarily with the public representation and relations of a movement in its attempts to win legitimacy and attract members through processes of frame alignment (Snow et al. 1986; Snow and Benford 1988). A focus on group interaction, on the other hand, centers on the patterns of interaction and problem-solving inside the group. Thus, we have a difference between internal interaction patterns and external communication.

This difference can be quite profound, as Eliasoph and Lichterman (2003) show in their ethnographic work, and in our case, we also find significant variations in the alignment between external framing and internal group style. Many groups describe themselves as strictly humanitarian

in their official self-presentation on Facebook using the same or similar wording. For instance, this central passage from the original Hjørring Friendly People group[1] appears in many group descriptions:

> We do not consider why the asylum seekers are here, or IF they should be here. We relate to THE FACT that they are here. So we leave it to the authorities to assess IF they have the right to be here. Until this decision, we are friendly and welcoming to them—this we believe is to show ordinary humanity and decency.

This humanitarian and non-contentious frame shared by many groups focuses on the help that can be given here and now and on the obligation to create a hospitable space for refugees. However, the actual interaction within these groups varied greatly regarding both how prevalent political critique was and the mood in which reports on humanitarian activism were communicated. In some groups, the suffering, hopelessness, and sorrow of refugees and political critique were a part of the day-to-day communication. In other groups, the mood was distinctly positive, and the style did not allow for negative stories and emotions or political critique. Elsewhere, we have labeled this *the Friendly Style* (Carlsen 2019; Carlsen et. al. forthcoming), similar to what has been characterized as ”nowtopianism” by Lichterman and Eliasoph (2014).

Group interaction and participation

In this section, we argue how group style has consequences for the individual’s participation in collective action. In short, group style constitutes the members’ shared understanding of a situation and system of typifications and relevancies which 1) *encodes habits of action and thought in the group members*, and 2) *captures and attunes the activist to certain aspects of the issue*. These two processes constitute our theoretical hypothesis that we subsequently will submit to statistical analyses. Arguing this, we pay special attention to the distinction between contentious and non-contentious group interaction and individual participation central to the case under study for the following reasons.

To Lichterman and Eliasoph 2014, the dimension of a conflictual or non-conflictual *map* is central in their typology of scene styles. Their concept map designates the interactants implicitly shared reference points to others (groups, settings, individuals) used to demarcate the group’s boundaries in the setting. Their relations to other groups in society can be imagined as conflictual or not. Likewise, Lichterman and Eliasoph’s focus on *speech norms* is important for our undertaking. It refers to which genres of talk and emotional tones are appropriate in a specific group setting (Lichterman and Eliasoph 2014:814). Contentious talk, where actors criticize the government or other actors, is a specific genre of talk, which theoretically should be important for engagement in protest activity. Additional reasons for focusing on this dimension is that contention is central to refugee solidarity activism, and more generally, the dimension of contention is central to social movement studies, often defined under the heading of *contentious politics*.

1. Encoding habits of action and thought

The first process linking group style to individual participation concerns how actors in a group develop habits of thought and action in relation to specific issues. As Lichterman & Eliasoph (2014) argue, different styles cultivate different skills among their participants. We adopt the pragmatist

conception of habits as arts or competences rather than mere behavioral repetition. For instance, one must learn how to think and talk contentiously about the refugee situation. Actors develop these competencies through situational tests where they learn what principles should be used in critique (Boltanski and Thévenot 2006) and what actions are appropriate and efficient. Activists learn certain imaginaries within the group setting that both work as moral compasses and help guide action (Braunstein 2017:152f). On a more practical note, activists gain familiarity with different movement activities and acquire the relevant skills such as how to organize demonstrations or how to help and support refugees.

This can be illustrated by an example from one of the more contentious groups where communication was filled with critical operations. Under the heading "The Danish Refugee Council's [a major pro-refugee NGO] legitimacy and trustworthiness is threatened," Kevin, a very active member of the group, criticizes a law proposal from the government that will remove the Danish Refugee Council's right to appoint representatives to the Danish Refugee Appeals Board [a central judicial authority in the asylum application process]. First, he introduces the procedure through which refugees apply for asylum. Then Kevin problematizes the law proposal, which, according to him, will weaken asylum seekers' legal rights. Such critique is common in this group, and, compared to many other Facebook groups, it is filled with opportunities for its members to learn the art of civic critique of immigration policies and the authorities.[2]

Our concept of habits invokes a sequential explanation in which the habits acquired through past activism make certain responses to present situations more probable (Gross 2009). This implies that we expect that a history of activism will mediate the influence of present group styles on differential participation in activism. For instance, when entering a new group, an activist with a long history of activism will align her choice of activities with the group style to a lesser degree than a novice activist who is just beginning to develop her habits of thought and action influenced by the group's style. Thus, in addition to expecting that being subject to a certain group style will encode habits of action and thought as well as competences that will determine what activities the individual participates in, we also expect the encoding process to be mediated by the habits and competences acquired by the individual before entering the group.

2. Flow engrossment—capturing and attuning the activist

The second process, flow engrossment, concerns how group style captures and attunes the activists to engage with the issues at hand in a certain way. Where the encoded habits of action have long-term consequences, flow works within the present and has immediate short-term consequences by attuning the actor to certain ways of engaging with the issue at hand. Goffman speaks of this as engrossment, meaning that the actor's entire attention is allocated exclusively to a specific form of engagement (Goffman 1974: 346). Thereby the actor becomes blind to alternative modes of engagement, for example, a shift from help to critique. In this way, group style attunes the actor's anticipation of what comes next and steers the engrossed actor through the flow of situations and issues in a way that narrows the scope of potential future actions that could arise out of the situation. Thus, a non-contentious, positive, and friendly group style will attune the activist to engage with issues and situations in ways that make a contentious action strategy less likely and vice versa.

Returning to the findings from the online ethnography, central to the refugee solidarity groups was the "mood" of the group, which made certain actions and thoughts natural and effortless while others seemed a hurdle (Silver 2011). For instance, in many Friendly People groups, positivity and friendliness in both written and pictorial communication had consequences for the situation and future action. Instead of displaying the suffering refugee, it was the joyful and giving interaction between Danes and refugees that was reported. The downplaying of suffering also makes victims hard to identify and persecutors completely absent. In cases where refugees' unfortunate situation was part of the communication, the question of responsibility for this situation was not brought up in groups with a strictly non-contentious group style. Consequently, switching from helping a refugee to criticizing those responsible for the refugee's unfortunate situation is highly unlikely because these groups' foci are elsewhere. In turn, it is even more unlikely that the group members will participate in political protest.

Flow engrossment also reveals how group styles filter information. This function is crucial for differential participation, because if one does not have information about future events, then surely it is impossible to participate in these events, unless by coincidence. To have relevance, information must be formatted in a way that fits the situation (Thévenot 2007). This implies that, in a group, ill-placed recruitment attempts not in alignment with the group style risk being ignored because the attuned activists dismiss them as background noise or breaches of group norms.

Through flow engrossment, the group style also extends its reach beyond the group setting and shapes how the activist relates to the political context outside the group. This can be in a very practical way. For instance, the more humanitarian actions one carries out, the more humanitarian problems one encounters because the attunement has affected the actor's way of engaging with new situations in a way that makes humanitarian issues stand out while other issues fade into the background (Silver 2011). Consequently, fewer resources are available for participating in political protests, also outside the group. Flow engrossment may also influence the actors in a more proactive way, such as when actors in a flow of action translate every problem into a humanitarian problem of what can be done here and now to help the unfortunate. Therefore, we expect that group style influences the individual's participation in activities not only within the group but also outside the group, although to a lesser extent due to the influence of the patterns of interaction of other settings.

Habits and engrossment vs. network socialization and framing

Finally, we shall shortly return to discuss how group interaction compares to the established conceptualizations of meso-level processes of network socialization and framing with regard to how they influence differential participation. We argue that group interaction 1) solves some well-know problems of reifying and static tendencies in relation to both network and SMO framing and 2) adds new aspects of group processes that have consequences for participation which 3) enables an analysis of the qualitatively different forms of participation that different group styles enable or undermine.

In movement networks, socialization is central to participation because it ensures commitment to the ideational factors of ideology and beliefs of the movement, that is, collective identity (Hensby 2014; Stekelenburg and Klandermans 2013), which in turn motivates participation. In this process,

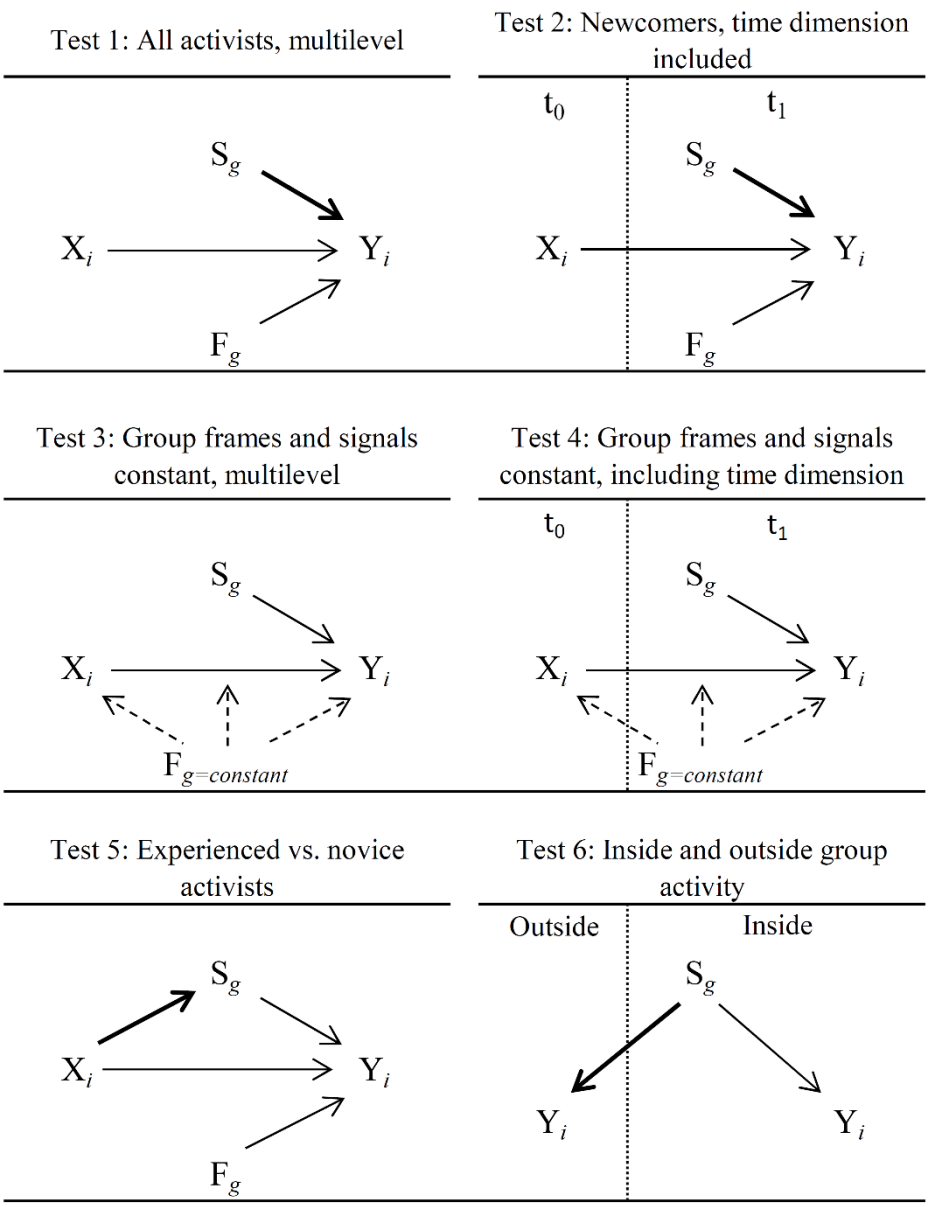
an important element is the framing of the movement's ideational foundation that diagnoses the problem and prescribes how to handle it (Snow and Benford 1988). Even though not the intent of David A. Snow and Robert D. Benford, reifying and static tendencies in relation to identity as well as the elite bias, and monolithic tendencies in the framing literature have been recognized as the major problem (Benford 1997; Snow et al. 2014). The group style perspective counters these tendencies by explicitly taking group interaction as the object of inquiry. This approach allows us to capture how "meaning-making" and identity are constantly renegotiated and reinvented at the micro level (Taylor and Whittier 1992). We thus focus on how these patterns of interaction, rather than merely the official frames of the organization or network ties, influence and disposition actors to engage in some forms of participation and not others. Consequently, we come very close to Snow and Benford's original intent to analyze meaning-making as an interactional accomplishment which preconditions mobilization (1988; Snow et al. 1986).

However, the encoding of habits of action also adds a focus on how not only ideational elements but also practical elements of socialization like learning skills and competences have consequences: What specific parts of a movement repertoire the single activist learns to master guides the activist's future actions in a certain direction aligned with this mastery. So do the learned emotional reactions to certain events (Carlsen 2019; Carlsen et al. forthcoming; Gundelach and Toubøl 2019), and many other skills and habits. In the same vein, flow engrossment guides participation because it influences what issues the single activist pays attention to because of the filtering and qualifying effects of group style, and how the activist engages with and acts upon the issues.

By making us attentive to the practical element of socialization, group interaction points in a new way to an old perspective on differential participation, namely that of the repertoire (Tilly 1977; 2008). Hitherto, differential participation has almost exclusively been a question of the cost and risk of activism (Exceptions are Barkan et al. 1995 and Passy and Giugni 2001). The main predictors have been network embeddedness and history of activism, both proxies for socialization and thereby strength of commitment to the collective identity (e.g., McAdam 1986; Wiltfang and McAdam 1991; Dauphinais et al. 1992; Nepstad and Smith 1999; Schussman & Soule 2005; Hensby 2014, Gundelach and Toubøl 2019). Thus, the core of the model is that the degree of identification determines the degree of participation along a dimension of the repertoire, typically cost or risk. Focusing on the practical elements of socialization provides an alternative to this focus on why some participate more, run higher risks, or pay a higher cost by asking how qualitatively different group styles, frames, or networks within the same movement condition participation in qualitatively different categories of the movement repertoire. Hence, in line with early formulations of the problem (e.g., Snow, Zurcher, and Ekland-Olson 1980), we hold that differential participation covers both difference in the degree of participation and difference in the type of participation. Thereby we get at the core of the repertoire concept by addressing "not only what people *do* when they are engaged in conflict with others, but *what they know how to do* and what others expect them to do" (Tarrow 2011:39, emphasis in original). The empirical analysis below addresses such a question, namely how contentious and non-contentious group styles relate to individual-level participation in political protest vs. humanitarian action.

4. Research design

Figure 1. Logical designs of six tests of the effect of group style on participation in political protest



Note: Y_i= The individuals level of participation in political protests during/after the September mobilization. X_i = Individual *i*'s characteristics. S_g= Group style. F_g = Framing of group. t_0 = Before Setpember mobilization. t_1 = During/after September mobilization. E_i = Activst experience of individual *i*.

We aim to substantiate empirically the theoretical claim that group interaction is important for explaining differential participation and demonstrate how this can be studied using quantitative methods at an aggregate level. Thereby, we add to the existing qualitative studies not only by investigating variation in the independent variable (group style) but also by analyzing how it correlates with the outcome variable of political protest. At the same time, we can control for alternative explanations of differential participation suggested in the literature.

The statistical analysis falls into two steps. First, we examine the overall hypothesis that *group style will influence the level of political protest engaged in by the individual independent of framing, network embedding, and individual characteristics.* Then we analyze the heterogeneity of the effect based on two hypotheses suggesting that *the level of prior activist experience* and whether the activity is *inside or outside the group* mediate the effect of group style on political protest.

These two steps are structured around six statistical tests. Tests 1, 2, 3, and 4 concern the first step of the analyses and test the overall hypothesis, whereas tests 5 and 6 concern the second step, testing for heterogeneity with regard to a history of activism and the group embeddedness of the activities. The diagrams in Figure 1 depict the logic of the tests. In Figure 1, *X* represents individual *i*'s characteristics, including network ties to individuals and organizations. *Y* shows the political protest individual *i* carried out during and/or after the September mobilization. *F* is the framing of group *g* that the individual is a member of, and *S* is the group style that influences individual *i*. The emboldened arrows highlight the focal relationship of the test.

Tests 1 and 2 concern the overall hypothesis that group style influences individual participation in political protest. In test 1, we estimate the statistical effect in a multilevel design allowing for controlling for unobserved variation among the groups. Test 2 introduces a time dimension distinguishing between t_0, before September, and t_1, during and after the September mobilization. This distinction is obtained by splitting the sample into veterans, active at t_0, and newcomers, not part of the movement until t_1. This concerns the degree to which the individuals themselves were involved in creating the group culture from the beginning or first entered the group at t_1. The distinction also concerns the length of time for which the individual has been part of the group and thereby has encoded the group style. Thus, test 2 concerns the group's effect on the new members who first became members during or after the September mobilization, t_1. Thereby, we attempt to exclude endogeneity because the individual characteristics have not influenced or been influenced by the group style.

In this study, we investigate differential participation and disregard the recruitment process. This makes our central proposition—that group style influences the activities of the group members—vulnerable because it can be argued that the variation in group style and activities may both be explained by unobserved selection in the recruitment process. Such self-selection would be due to the group's self-description and reputation. To counter this potential fallacy, we designed tests 3 and 4. Tests 3 and 4 only consider one faction of groups in the movement, namely the Friendly People, which is by far the largest movement faction. The Friendly People groups are characterized by having a uniform framing, with regard to both how they are generally portrayed in the media and how they describe themselves in various self-presentations such as Facebook group descriptions, which, in most cases, are the only information available to potential members until they join the group. Thus, these groups' reputation and self-description are close to identical. By considering

only these groups, we come as close as we can to holding constant any effect of group framing, *F*—whether it relates to the selection of members or the direct or mediating diagnostic, prognostic, and motivational effects of framing on activity, *Y*. Test 4 considers only newcomers, thus also controlling for the potential endogeneity of the activists themselves contributing to the formation of the group style. Thereby tests 3 and 4 are likely to test effectively for potential unobserved selection effects in the recruitment process. We acknowledge that our design does not perfectly control for potential selection effects and that it has the same weakness of many observational studies where the data does not lend itself to a natural experiment.

To investigate heterogeneity, test 5 splits the population by history of refugee activism to examine whether the level of experience, *E*, influences the effect of contentious group style, *S*, on the contentious action, *Y*, of individual *i*. In accordance with our theory, we would expect that the experienced activist with a long history of activism would be less affected by the group style due to stronger habits, whereas non-experienced activists would have no experience and habits to guide them in this respect, and, therefore, to a greater degree align with the group style. Test 6 distinguishes between participation in activities within and outside the group. The straightforward hypothesis is that group style has more to say about in-group activities than outside group activities. However, in line with our theoretical assumption of attunement to group style, we expect it to influence participation outside the group as well.

Data

Data stems from two sources, which we combine: 1) individual-level survey data and 2) group-level "big" social media data of interactions within the Facebook groups.

The survey data is used to measure individual properties, network embeddedness, and the dependent variable of the individual's participation in political protest. We exploit data from a survey with a total of 2,289 respondents recruited online in the Facebook groups of the movement. Carried out during the summer of 2016, the online survey of movement participants inquires about the individual's actions and experiences in relation to the September mobilization (Toubøl 2017). These events constitute a public event fixed in time, about which people in Denmark in general and activists in particular have a clear memory. Furthermore, by focusing on the event of the September mobilization, we can distinguish between before and after in the questions asked, which allows the inclusion of the dimension of time. Even though focusing our inquiries on a significant event allows for a better retrospective investigation (Belli 2014), the problem of recollection can by no means be ruled out. For these reasons, we do not claim that we observe a causal relationship—merely the likelihood of such a relationship between variables, which at best provides the theoretical argument with plausibility.

In addition to inquiring about the September mobilization, the questionnaire asks about movement and civic activities, motives, attitudes, and beliefs as well as individual and socioeconomic characteristics at a more general level. The survey includes information on the respondent's primary Facebook group affiliation used to link the individual to measures of the interaction in this particular group, which will be explained in more detail below. Finally, the survey contains information about whether activities were carried out within or outside the group, enabling us to investigate the heterogeneity of the effect of group style along this dimension.

How well the survey sample represents the population of movement members active on Facebook is crucial to the question of the possible inference from the sample to the population. In this regard, the scope of available Facebook data limits the available population-level variables that at the same time are relevant and suitable for comparison with the survey variables. Therefore, we are able only to test representativeness on two dimensions, gender and political orientation. Gender is a general standard measure when it comes to sample representativeness, and political orientation is of particular relevance to this study as we are dealing with the question of political action. The test (for details see appendix 2) shows that the sample reflects the population being politically left-leaning and predominantly made up of women, but at the same time, the sample over-represents both left-leaning activists and women. One plausible explanation is that the movement is led by women and left-leaning activists who, therefore, have a higher chance of responding to the survey. In sum, based on these two indicators, representativeness is deemed acceptable.

The second source is data collected on Facebook. Social media bias is less worrisome in a Danish context, where 67 percent of the total population aged 16-89 use Facebook, and when looking only at Internet users, at least 96 percent are Facebook users (Tassy 2016). The data from the Facebook groups are used to measure variation in group interactions along the dimension of contentiousness. A keyword search using the search interface within Facebook identified 119 relevant Facebook groups.

Dependent variable: political protest

Table 1 summarizes the variables included in the models. The dependent variable—*political protest*—(see Table 2) is based on a set of 16 items asking about activities in which the respondents have been involved. In the following, we consider only activities that took place during or after the September mobilization to synchronize the activities with our measure of group interaction.

Seven of the 16 activities have been categorized as political protest.[3] They cover traditional means of political protest such as demonstration and petitioning. However, they also include several activities characteristic of this particular movement's repertoire, namely civil disobedience in relation to preventing the deportation of refugees. While activities such as providing support for underground refugees or hiding refugees from the authorities are also in part motivated by humanitarian concerns, they constitute acts of defying the authorities (Wiltfang and Cochran 1994). Thus, as shown elsewhere in relation to the same case, these activities are viewed as acts of political protest or defiance by the actors themselves (Toubøl 2019).

When splitting the sample in tests 2-6, due to the smaller N, the variable was recoded into a binary, simply distinguishing between being engaged in contentious action or not. It is important to note that a low or zero score on the political protest variable does not entail a low level of activity but indicates that the respondent rather participates in humanitarian activities.

Focal independent variable: group style

The following section provides context on how the focal independent variable—*contentious group style*—was defined qualitatively, and introduces the coding scheme used to construct labels for the machine learning classifier using an expert coding strategy.

Table 1. Summary of variables included in statistical models

Variable (type)	n	Mean	S.D.	Min.	Max.
Political protest (scale)	1,364	0.860	0.945	0	4
Contentiousness of group style (scale)	1,364	0.048	0.046	0	1
Contentious framing (dummy)	1,364	1.025	0.156	1	2
Personal network (scale)	1,364	0.885	0.913	0	2
Organizational network (dummy)	1,364	0.061	0.239	0	1
Political civil society embeddedness (scale)	1,364	4.228	1.688	0	9
Non-political civil society embeddedness (scale)	1,364	3.850	2.044	0	9
Emotional response (scale)	1,364	3.463	0.975	0	4
Income (scale)	1,364	3.002	1.154	1	5
Worktime (scale)	1,364	1.816	1.596	0	5
Highest level of education (scale)	1,364	4.127	0.958	1	5
Degree of urbanization (scale)	1,364	3.424	1.232	1	5
Children in household (dummy)	1,364	0.460	0.499	0	1
Age (scale)	1,364	48.822	13.849	15	84
Refugee (dummy)	1,364	1.970	0.171	1	2
Active before September (dummy)	1,364	0.538	0.499	0	1
Prior history of activism (scale)	1,364	1.754	1.638	0	5
Prior history of refugee activism (scale)	1,364	0.877	1.313	0	5
Self-transcendent values (scale)	1,364	5.556	1.797	1	8
Self-enhancement values (scale)	1,364	3.669	1.483	1	7
Political attitude (scale)	1,364	2.117	0.893	1	4
Frequency of church attendance (scale)	1,364	1.013	1.127	0	4
Categorical variables	n	Percent			
Occupation					
Full time	606	44	-	-	-
Part time	119	9	-	-	-
Self-employed	118	9	-	-	-
Student	110	8	-	-	-
Unemployment	61	4	-	-	-
Early retirement	60	4	-	-	-
Retired	189	14	-	-	-
Other	101	7	-	-	-
Gender					
Female	1,172	86	-	-	-
Male	185	14	-	-	-
Identify as neither	7	1			
Religion		-	-	-	-
Non-believer	686	50	-	-	-
Danish National Church	594	44	-	-	-
Islam	22	2	-	-	-
Other	62	5	-	-	-

We coded statements that were both implicitly and explicitly critical of other parties ranging from well-articulated critiques to implicit references to others harming the common cause. Vague references or references to a commonly known situation, values, and so forth were also coded using our cultural expertise gathered through the qualitative fieldwork. Lastly, we coded each statement in the context of other statements, such that the coders were presented with posts and the related

comments, which were presented to the coder in chronological fashion, allowing the coder to keep track of the surrounding political events that might be of relevance to understanding the statements. One example of how these decisions helped ensure semantic validity is a post where a refugee writes “Blue Monday.” This post read in isolation could refer to many different things (e.g., a Danish coming-of-age ritual), but read in context of the comments and wider political situation the posts meaning is rather clear. It was written on the Monday after the Danish election in which the right wing won by popular vote and the anti-immigration party, the Danish People’s Party, had their best election ever.

Table 2. Frequency of political protest

# Activities	Frequency	Percentage	Cumulative %
0	546	43.61	43.61
1	418	32.20	76.81
2	232	18.43	95.23
3	33	2.62	97.86
4-7	27	2.14	100.00
Total	1,259	100.00	

Note. This table includes only the observations that are included in the statistical model of Table V, and thus are not missing on any of the variables included and where group size>5.

Coding the communication within the group has the advantage of being as close to the interaction as possible, allowing us to test a rather subtle difference between a group’s official framing and the actual patterns of interaction. Much like ethnographic analysis of the relations between official talk and actual practice (Jerolmack and Khan 2015; Eliasoph and Litcherman 2003), having two separate variables—one for the official framing and one for the interactional order—allows us to explicate this difference. With this strategy, we follow Lichterman and Eliasoph’s 2014 proposal that one should use more mundane online scenes as opposed to official documents to measure scene style (2014: 841).

Using the above-described coding scheme, the authors labeled a random sample of 12,500 posts and comments used as training data in the supervised machine learning. The approach builds on recent developments within the field of natural language processing and its adoption in the social sciences (Evans and Aceves 2016). Evaluating the performance of the resulting classifier shows that it was able to recognize a quite substantial part of the contentious signal in the textual data (AUC score: 0.941; Accuracy: 0.965; Precision: 0.910; Recall: 0.590) and beat standard baseline models in text classification by a substantial margin (see Supplementary Materials Part 1 for a more detailed description of the model specification and evaluation). To evaluate potential bias due to the recall rate, we have run a sensitivity analysis changing the decision boundary to get a higher recall. The results are robust to a level of 0.90 recall (see Supplementary Materials Part 1, Figure S3). The resulting classifier was then applied to the full social media dataset (640,000+ posts and comments) to estimate the level of contentious group interactions in each group. Results from the classifier were aggregated to a group-level measure of contentiousness. The final group style variable

measures the proportion of contentious statements during October and November in the single groups weighted by the total number of statements per month in the groups. We do not include September because, even though most of the 119 groups were created before September, 23 were created during September. Contentious group style continuously ranges from 0–1, but the very low mean (0.048) and S.D. (0.046) reveal that it generally operates at the lower end of this range.

Our approach to large-scale text analysis differs from dominant approaches such as topic modeling and dictionary approaches (Grimmer and Steward 2013; Evans and Aceves 2016). On the analytical side, our hypothesis and text category are driven by our theoretical interests and qualitative analysis as opposed to patterns that the model returns (topic modeling). This, in part, overcomes some of the problems of large-scale text classification such as the lack of semantic validity, empirical grounding, and theoretical relevance (Bail 2014; Lichterman and Eliasoph 2014). The use of supervised machine learning gives us explicit measures of measurement quality, such as precision and recall. This enables us to handle some of the very valid worries about measurement error in large-scale text analysis (Grimmer and Steward 2013).

Control variables

Turning to the control variables, group framing is of particular theoretical interest. It is a group-level variable distinguishing between groups that frame their activity and purpose as non-contentious or contentious. All Facebook groups have a description section that contains information about the group which is made available to potential members. A typical example of such a description was presented in section 3. From these descriptions, we constructed the variable *contentious framing* by coding the group descriptions of all the groups as contentious or not. In addition to this group-level control, the models include a wide range of individual-level variables covering network embeddedness, history of activism, emotions, value-predispositions, biographical availability, and more from the survey data (for details, see Supplementary Materials - Part 2).

5. Results

Test 1 aims to assess the plausibility of the overall hypothesis that group style independently influences individual participation in political protest. It is specified as a random intercept two-level Poisson regression model with Facebook groups as the group level.

Table 3 reports the results. Model 1 includes only the focal relationship of contentious group style on political protest and models 2 and 3 include the framing variable and network variables, respectively. Model 4 includes all the meso-level variables measuring group style, framing, and networks. Finally, in model 5, we also include the individual-level controls (we report only the significant estimates of the individual-level controls. For a full list of estimates, see Appendix, Table A2).

Regarding the effect of contentious group style, it is substantial and significant in all the models. Even though the effect is reduced when adding the controls, it is the largest of the meso-level factors. The effect of framing is significant in models 2 and 4 but turns insignificant when the individual-level controls are added. However, variation in this variable is modest and, therefore, and because the model is designed to test the effect of group style and not framing, we hesitate to conclude that framing does not matter. Of the network measures, only embeddedness in political civil society and being active before September are significant and have a positive effect.

Table 3. Random intercept Poisson regression models of participation in political protest (0-4)

Covariate	1. Focal relationship		2. Framing		3. Networks		4. Meso-level factors		5. All controls	
	Coef.	S.E.	Coef.	S.E.	Coef.	S.E.	Coef.	S.E.	Coef.	S.E.
Group level										
Contentiousness of group style	6.542***	1.806					4.807**	1.683	3.606**	1.307
Contentious framing			0.588**	0.217			0.456*	0.218	0.283	0.201
Individual level										
Personal network					0.032	0.035	0.028	0.034	0.016	0.035
Organizational network					-0.097	0.141	-0.111	0.140	0.003	0.141
Political civil society embed.					0.079***	0.183	0.078***	0.018	0.051**	0.019
Non-political civil society embed.					-0.039*	0.015	-0.038*	0.0154	-0.005	0.016
Active before September					0.371***	0.065	0.364***	0.065	0.226***	0.031
History of activism									-0.126***	0.031
History of refugee activism									0.176***	0.350
Emotional response									0.290***	0.049
Self-transcendent values									0.038*	0.019
Self-enhancement values									-0.048*	0.023
Political attitude									-0.190***	0.041
Religion										
Non-believer									Reference	
Danish National Church									-0.267**	0.084
Islam									0.012	0.231
Other									0.049	0.146
Degree of urbanization									0.072*	0.031
Additional covariates	-		-		-		-		+	
Constant	-0.622***	0.093	-0.982***	0.229	-1.177***	0.151	-1.788***	0.257	-2.953***	0.718
Random effects										
Var. constant	0.123	0.041	0.143	0.042	0.140	0.042	0.088	0.032	0.023	0.015
Degrees of freedom	1		1		5		7		34	
Log likelihood	-1485.807		-1488.323		-1460.720		-1453.564		-.1354.9729	

Note: *=p-value<0.05; **=p-value<0.01; ***=p-value<0.001. Total individual observations in all models=1,259. Total groups in all models=75. Coefficients are unstandardized. In model 5, only significant estimates of controls and estimates of variables of special theoretical interest estimates are reported. For full list of estimates, see Supplementary Materials – Part 3.

Test 2 isolates the sub-population of newcomers to ensure that the observed relationship in test 1 is not simply the product of veteran activists having aligned their habits of action with the group style. Due to the smaller number of observations in the sub-sample, it is estimated as a logistic regression model distinguishing between whether the individual was involved in political protest or not. In Table 4, we report the estimates that confirm the result of test 1.[4]

Table 4. Logistic regression models of newcomers' participation in political protest (0-1)

Covariate	1. Focal relationship		2. Meso-level factors		3. All controls	
	Coef.	S.E.	Coef.	S.E.	Coef.	S.E.
Group level						
Contentiousness of group style	10.087***	2.770	9.369**	2.850	7.371*	3.313
Contentious framing			1.029	0.976	0.300	0.944
Individual level						
Personal network			-0.025	0.092	-0.008	0.107
Organizational network			-0.176	0.388	-0.110	0.430
Political civil society embed.			0.160**	0.054	0.085	0.061
Non-pol. civil society embed.			-0.133**	0.043	-0.036	0.053
History of refugee activism					0.390***	0.108
Emotional response					0.552***	0.122
Political attitude					-0.500***	0.113
Religion						
Non-believer					Reference	
Danish National Church					-0.464*	0.228
Islam					-0.143	0.789
Other					0.557	0.473
Additional covariates	-		-		+	
Constant	-.504***	0.142	-1.63	1.02	-2.838	2.706
Pseudo R^2	0.017		0.039		0.180	
Degrees of freedom	1		6		33	
Log likelihood	-428.751		-419.122		-357.718	

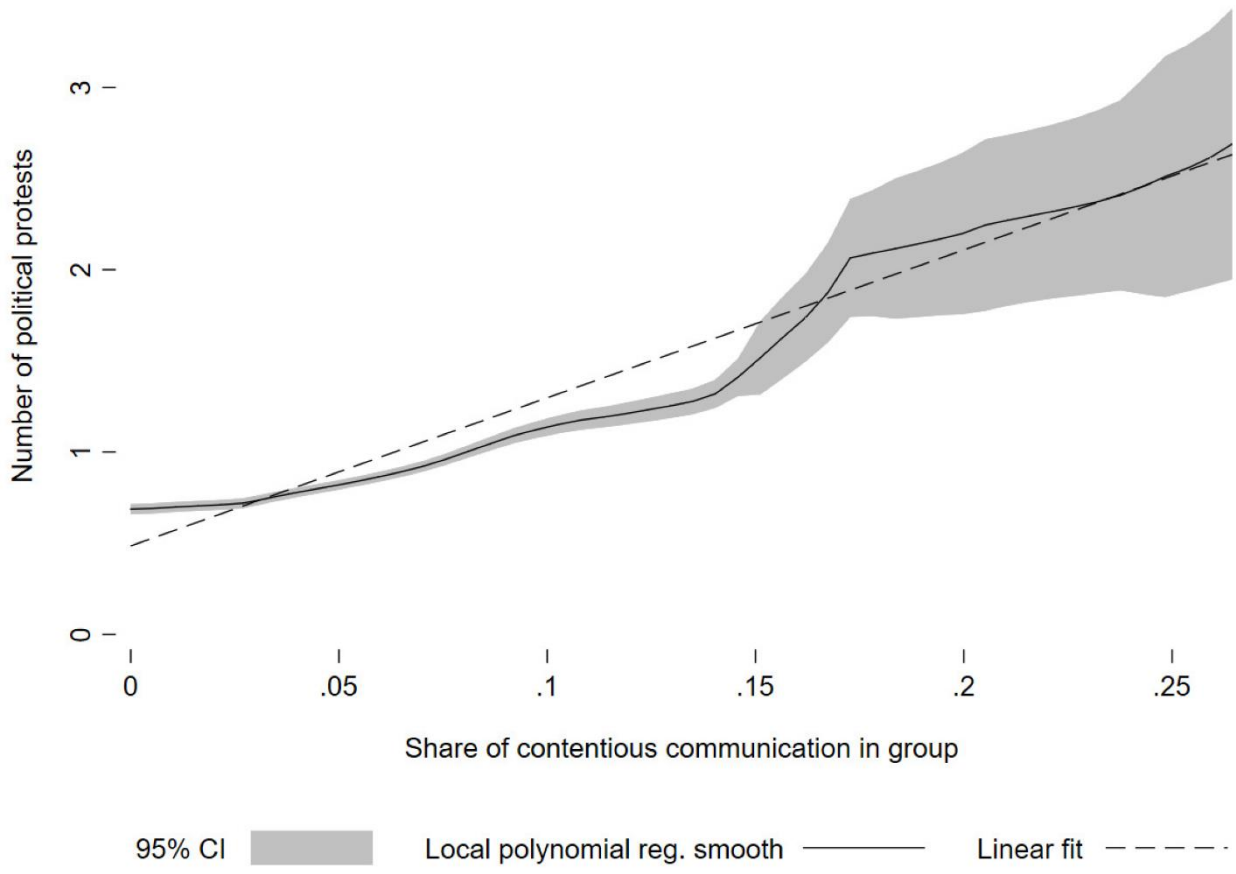
Note. *=p-value<0.05; **=p-value<0.01; ***=p-value<0.001. S.E. is robust. Observations in all models=630. Coefficients are unstandardized. For model 3, only significant estimates of controls and estimates of variables of special theoretical interest estimates are reported. For full list of estimates, see Supplementary Materials – Part 3.

The results of tests 3 and 4, which were designed to control for potential unobserved selection in the recruitment process, also find a large statistically significant effect of group style and participation in political protest (see Supplementary Materials – Part 3 for a full list of model estimates). Even though not conclusive, the result indicates that it is unlikely that unobserved selection effects in the recruitment process render the observed relationship between group style and differential participation spurious.

Overall, tests 1, 2, 3, and 4 support the overall hypothesis that group style influences the kind of collective actions in which the individual participates. To get a sense of the predicted impact, Figure 2 shows the non-parametric regression curves of the predicted values of the random intercept model 5 in Table 3. The horizontal axis measures the share of contentious communication in the Facebook groups and the vertical axis the number of political protests the individuals participate in. The contentious group style variable primarily operates in the lower spectrum of its principal range of 0–1, revealing that, in general, contentious interaction is rare in the movement, which aligns with

the fact that the movement is predominantly humanitarian, as explained in the case description. Consequential, in Figure 2 we consider only the lower quarter of the range. Throughout this spectrum, the degree of involvement in political protest increases with the level of contentious group style. However, it is close to flat before 0.1. Around 0.17, the effect accelerates to flatten out after 0.2. The S-curved relationship suggests that when the degree of contentious group style reaches a certain level, a more dramatic shift in the internal group dynamics with regard to participation in political protest occurs. Even though we consider only the lower end of the x-axis, going from 0 percent to ca. 20 percent, contentious group style increases individual participation in political protest by 1.5 on a scale from 0–4. Thus, the predicted effect is substantial.

Figure 2. Non-parametric regression curves of predicted values of random intercept model 3 for focal variable relationship between contentiousness of group style and political protest



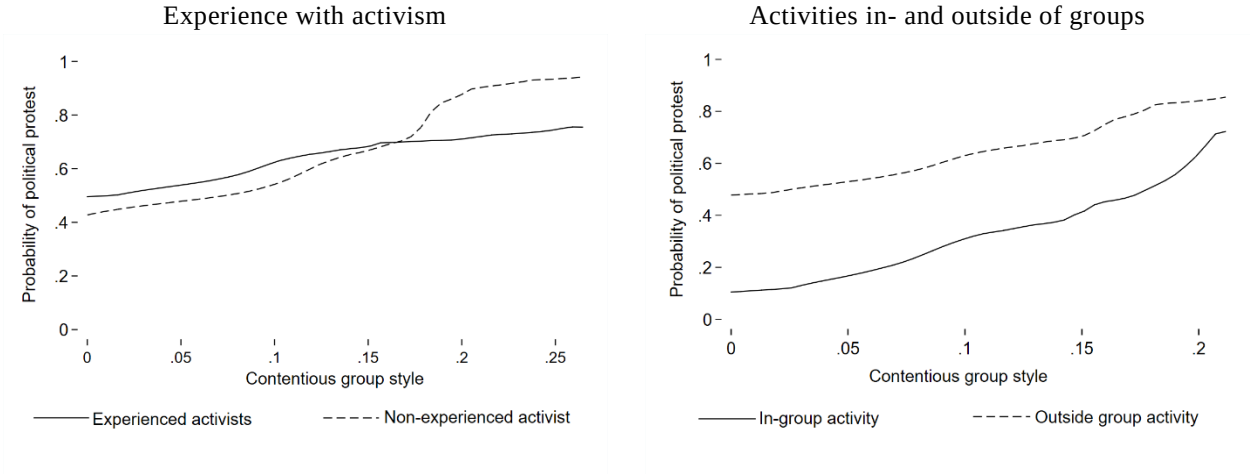
Heterogeneous effects

To investigate possible heterogeneity of the effect, we estimate two logistic models, one for activists with no history of refugee activism and one for activists with a history of activism. The model estimates can be found in Supplementary Materials – Part 3. In both models, contentious group style is significant. However, for those with a low history of activism (coefficient=13.961***; robust S.E.=3.336), it is much higher than those with a high history of

activism (coefficient=5.640*; robust S.E.=2.650). Figure 3 depicts non-parametric local regression of the predicted values. As expected, this suggests that seasoned activists are more resilient to effects of group style, whereas group style strongly influences novice activists.

In test 6, we examine the heterogeneity with regard to whether the activities take place within or outside the group. We estimate two logistic models for in- and outside-group activities. The model estimates can be found in Supplementary Materials – Part 3. In accordance with our theoretical expectations, the effect of contentious group style on outside-group political protest is also significant (coefficient=7.730***; robust S.E.=2.096), even though, as anticipated, the effect on in-group political protest (coefficient=20.241***; robust S.E.=4.471) is much larger, as is also depicted in Figure 3.

Figure 3. Heterogeneity with regard to experience and activities embeddedness in group



Note: For the model estimates, see Supplementary Materials – Part 3.

To summarize, all six tests support our theoretical hypotheses regarding the importance of the neglected dimension of group style for differential participation, and the presence of a substantial effect seems to be quite robust. Even though the empirical design does not allow for making causal claims, the results do increase the plausibility of the theoretical argument and demonstrate how group interaction can be analyzed in a statistical research design.

6. Discussion & Conclusion

Overall, the results support that group style correlates positively with individual participation in collective action along the dimension of contentiousness. That contentious group style influences individual engagement in political protest points to the importance of in situ group interaction as a distinct meso level of analysis.

Furthermore, the results, as expected, show that a history of activism and the implied encoded habits of action and thought mediate the relationship between group style and individual activity. A seasoned activist with established habits of action, entering a new group, does not become engrossed in the form of engagement enacted within the group to the same extent as a novice activist. What goes on inside the group does not come to define the issue totally, even though it

does affect individual engagement to some degree. For the novice, the opposite is the case; when she enters the group and the movement without any habits of action, the group style is there to direct thoughts and action.

This brings us to the relationship between activities organized within one's group and activities taking place outside the group. If group style were completely endogenous to group activities, one would expect that group style would become superfluous in relation to external group activity. However, this is not the case as we observe a significant influence of contentious group style participation on political protest outside the group. That patterns of group interaction encode themselves in activists and become consequential in other settings at other times (McAdam 1988; Whittier 1997) points to the importance of group interaction more generally and not just in relation to the activities studied here.

These results do not undermine the importance of framing for differential participation. Frames still have explanatory power. Also, a group's official framing is, of course, important because, unlike everyday talk, it cannot be ignored as mere talk and, in many cases, must be seen as a privileged part of group discourse. However, our results underline that the interactional and situational aspects of Goffman's theoretical endeavor should also be considered.

As with framing, individual network embeddedness still matters for differential participation. Structural availability makes it more likely for individuals to participate in contentious activities as expected. Still, the effect is modest, which is in line with other studies of differential participation (e.g., Passy 2001; Gundelach and Toubøl 2019). The results also confirm that ties are not just ties, and that the distinction between weak and strong is far from sufficient, which has long been recognized among social movement network scholars (e.g., McAdam and Paulsen 1993; McAdam 2003; Passy and Monsch 2014; Tindall 2015). We find that what matters for participation in political protest is embeddedness in *political* civil society organizations and not civil society per se. Still, the black box of network ties and processes needs unlocking. Our proposition is that paying attention to patterns of group interaction will help understand ties by uncovering what it is the network makes the individual structurally exposed to (Carlsen et al. 2020; Passy and Monsch 2020). However, it should be noted that the group style perspective also offers a perspective of the foci of the group dynamics and interaction that goes beyond what can be achieved by social network analysis.

The results presented above are, for several reasons, far from conclusive regarding the question of what accounts for differential participation. Improvement of the group style measure by including more dimensions is a necessary future task, as well as relating it to outcomes other than individual participation in collective action. Furthermore, we do not empirically assess how flow engrossment and habits of thought and action have distinct consequences for differential participation. This would require more dynamic participation data allowing for distinguishing between short- and long-term effects.

A last set of concerns relates to the use of Facebook communication to analyze interactional styles. Our use of Facebook to capture styles of interaction is dependent on the social movement groups' use of Facebook. In our case, the refugee solidarity groups used Facebook groups to coordinate action and share experiences within the group. Hence, the scene styles were identifiable from Facebook interaction. However, this will not be possible in the case of many advocacy and

social movement groups that use their Facebook page only as a means to communicate with large audiences and not to coordinate and negotiate action (Bail 2016; Mercea 2013).

Despite these reservations, this paper has made the case that group style matters for differential participation and group interaction should be analytically distinguished from network and framing as an important meso-level determinant of social movement repertoires. In doing so, the successful application of supervised machine learning demonstrating that natural language processing and machine learning algorithms can be tailored to replicate evaluations made by qualitative researchers points to the new methodological opportunities of social media data and digital methods within the field of sociology.

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Endnotes

1. For a detailed summary of a case analysis of this paradigmatic non-contentious group, see appendix A.
2. For a detailed summary of a case analysis of a paradigmatic contentious group, see appendix A.
3. See Appendix C for a table listing the activities and their classification as either political protest or non-contentious.
4. A similar model for only the veterans reveals similar findings. See Appendix H.

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Appendices

Appendix 1. Summary of case analyses of the Friendly People and Grandparents for Asylum

Below, we summarize case analyses of two central groups in the movement. First, the original Friendly People group that practices a distinct non-contentious "friendly" style. The second group is the Grandparents for Asylum, which is a paradigmatic example of a contentious interactional style. All quotes were originally in Danish and have been translated by the authors.

The first Friendly People group

This first group is historically central to the whole movement as it was the first Friendly People group, and its specific history has great consequence for how humanitarian action would be practiced and political denunciation would be viewed and resisted. This Friendly People group started as an initiative with nothing to do with refugees. Its conceptual and practical development came out of involvement with social welfare work (with socioeconomically deprived residential areas, old people's homes) and a group of people working toward making their municipality "the most friendly municipality in the country." A year or so before refugees moved to the center of the group's activities, it was founded as a place where people learned to see, appreciate, and be more friendly in their everyday lives. As *the* central actor in the group put in her updated Facebook group description:

> Do you want to make Hjørring municipality the friendliest in the country? We are a bunch of people from Hjørring who have gotten the idea that friendliness is something we can spread. We are called "The Friendly People," and we really want a lot of members. This page is meant to be a source of inspiration. We want to inspire people to focus on the joy of receiving kindness and the joy of being kind. We will give you small friendliness-assignments and hope that many people will write on this page and tell about the kinds of friendly engagement they have experienced. All the best, "The Friendly People."

This post is followed by a lot of small posts about how to make our everyday lives a bit friendlier. A video of seemingly random people on the street bluntly stating how much they appreciate the other person with whom they were walking—looking straight at them while the others blush, smile, and laugh. One of the co-founders tells how they were at the beach with lots of food, drinks, and so on to enjoy themselves. Next to them was an elderly couple with nothing. So, the women went over to them and asked if they wanted some coffee and cake. The couple were extremely surprised and said that they would never forget this and that the experience had made their day into a marvelous one.

From the beginning, this commitment to the small acts of friendliness, to a positive mood, and to sharing and spreading friendliness was that which made a Friendly Person. As another of its early members put it, "A Friendly Person always has sunshine in his heart on a cloudy day. A Friendly Person brings light and warmth to your everyday. A Friendly person understands how to listen when life is against you. Wonderful to be surrounded by Friendly People."

Although the positive affirmation of what made a Friendly Person was rather well articulated and a recurring ritual, there was very little about the other, the 'unfriendly' people, even as the group

started to be deeply committed to the refugee issue. The most dramatic illustration of this is the lack of reference to any of the many anti-immigration politicians or parties that were elected to the Danish Parliament during the period of the study. I found only one reference to the most iconic anti-immigrant politician of the time, a post that was not applauded with likes or comments. Not even an ironic depiction of absurd unfriendly activity received any attention. There is only one reference to the large national conservative Danish People's Party, and this is in a comment in which the author states her dislike toward the us/them distinctions and illustrates the fruitfulness of friendliness through her pleasant experience with a Danish People's Party representative resulting from her own initial friendliness. The post with the clearest negative identification and support from a central figure in the group was posted rather early before the national fame of the Friendly People. Here, a certain anger and resentment toward the tone, prejudice, and generalizations against immigrants communicate clearly from the text. However, it does this while still focusing on being open, friendly, and respectful of diversity and does not get more contentious than that. Its position is one of common decency rather than radical politics.

The group is also strongly embedded in their local community, both in their self-understanding, their practices, and the motives for becoming a refugee grass-root initiative. The refugees first became a concern when they came to the municipality, and the goal was to make them "feel welcome with us." The help that was initially proposed was everyday material stuff and social events. That is, to begin with, juridical help or political solidarity and support was not on the agenda. In several descriptions of the initiative, one of the leading figures says that she was worried about how the local community might react to refugees and that she sensed some negative sentiments and prejudice. The initiative was also intended to counteract these local negative sentiments by creating a platform for cross-cultural interaction. The very few claim-making efforts I found in the group were also directed against the local community, as when one activist states that she agrees with one of the leaders that their "local area could do more to make people feel welcome." One of the group's first activities was to show refugees around town by bicycle.

The group boundaries, their definition and enactment of good membership, their speech norms, and the mood within the group all point to a certain *Friendly style* in which humanitarian action simply is an extension of generally friendly engagement with the world. Political denunciation breaches all aspects of the scene style, and, most dramatically, political expression and political "objects" seem to resonate very little within the group at large; unlike other groups, there was no need to discourage political talk because it seldom happened and attracted very little attention. In many of the other humanitarian-only groups studied, the administrators had to remind people of the non-political focus of the group. This friendly style had consequences for the type of activity that the group facilitated. While Christmas arrangements were hugely popular, the biggest national refugee political event, a large demonstration, was largely ignored.

Grandparents for Asylum

The Friendly People ignoring the large pro-refugee 2015 demonstration stands in great contrast to Grandparents for Asylum (GPA) whose invitations to their own and other organizations' demonstrations and protest events are a completely natural part of the communication within the group. This is because everything within the scene has to do with articulating discontent and

opposition toward how refugees are treated in asylum centers and providing opportunities to take action.

The group's self-description on Facebook describes a contentious style, reflecting the focus on political protest. Before any explanation of the group's purpose, there is an instruction on how to subscribe to their newsletter. Next, information about the place and time for their bi-weekly combined meetings and demonstrations is presented, suggesting that one simply should show up and take part in order to join. A third section explains that there are additional demonstrations and directs the reader to the calendar module for further information. After these three bullets about how to take action, there follows a short description of the groups:

> Grandparents for Asylum is a movement of individuals. We are independent of political groups. What we want is to change Danish immigration [Asylum] policy to make it more humane, open, and inclusive. We do not think that people who have applied for asylum in Denmark but been rejected, should waste years of their lives in refugee camps without hope, fearful, and uncertain of what their future will look like.

Read Grandparents for Asylum's 10 demands for a decent Danish immigration policy on [link]. This presentation forefronts action and provides instructions on how to take action before turning to explain on what grounds they take action and what they aim to achieve. In this latter part, the framing is exemplary of how the contentious groups, in general, describe and justify their aims and actions. The perceived suffering of refugees and asylum seekers inflicted by Danish authorities and immigration policies motivates the need to change Danish policy to stop the treatment of refugees that is not considered humane and "decent."

The communication in the Grandparents for Asylum reflects this action-focused description. The bulk of posts are announcements of opportunities to take action, such as demonstration, petitions, and opportunities for influencing the political process by participating in public hearings. Another category of post is information sharing such as short follow-up reports and photos from protest events, critical newspaper articles, information about developments in Danish immigration policies, the members' own political analyses of the situation in Denmark, but also about the situation and international political context of major conflicts around the globe. A third category of posts involves refugees or activists sharing testimonies of the perceived unfairness of the Danish immigration system and the perceived suffering it inflicts on refugees and asylum seekers. Opposite to the positive and happy refugee stories shared in the Friendly People groups, these testimonies focus on the suffering and tragedy of the refugees.

This pattern of communication shows how the group's boundaries are defined by care and solidarity with the refugees and the willingness to take action and protest and oppose unfair policies by any means available, institutional as well extra-institutional. Thus, us/them distinctions are pronounced and central to the contentious group style and collective identity of GPA. This is contrary to the Friendly People where breaking down or downplaying us/them distinctions were a virtue. The prominence of us/them distinctions and willingness to take political action is also reflected in the group bonds. They are upheld through participating in or endorsing collective action. Online, this becomes visible in the frequent sharing of reports from various events organized by GPA. The reports receive many positive reactions. The speech norms are dominated by being political and contentious. Characterizing anti-immigrant politicians, policies, actions and events as

“inhumane,” “indecent,” “mean,” or “heartless” is common. When refugees share their stories of despair and suffering, the activists will not only express their sympathy and solidarity but also link the misery to the unfairness and inhumanity of the system and politicians and thereby identify a perpetrator. In contrast, when stories of refugees’ despair rarely were shared in the Friendly People group, the activist would likewise express sympathy and solidarity. However, they would not relate it to politics, and no perpetrator would be identified.

The communication in the GPA group distinguishes itself from the Friendly People group by being much more integrated and open to the rest of the movement, including the Friendly People. The majority of posts relate to activities organized by other organizations or groups, and other organizations are free to post and advertise their activities in the group. Thus, more than just a place for coordinating internal activities, the GPA group is also a communication hub for activities in the wider movement. This stands in stark contrast to the Friendly People groups, where the focus is on cultivating emotions and moods of positivity and friendliness internally in the group.

However, despite the many differences, the two groups have one thing in common beyond being preoccupied with refugee issues. The posts with testimonies and stories about refugees, no matter whether they are stories of happiness or pain, attract the most attention and receive the most reactions. This commonality indicates how activists feeling responsible for the refugees and the preservation of their life and dignity define the overall refugee solidarity movements’ collective identity-based on a shared humanistic worldview.

Appendix 2. Sample representativeness

Figure A1. Political orientation of Facebook population and survey sample (95 percent CI)

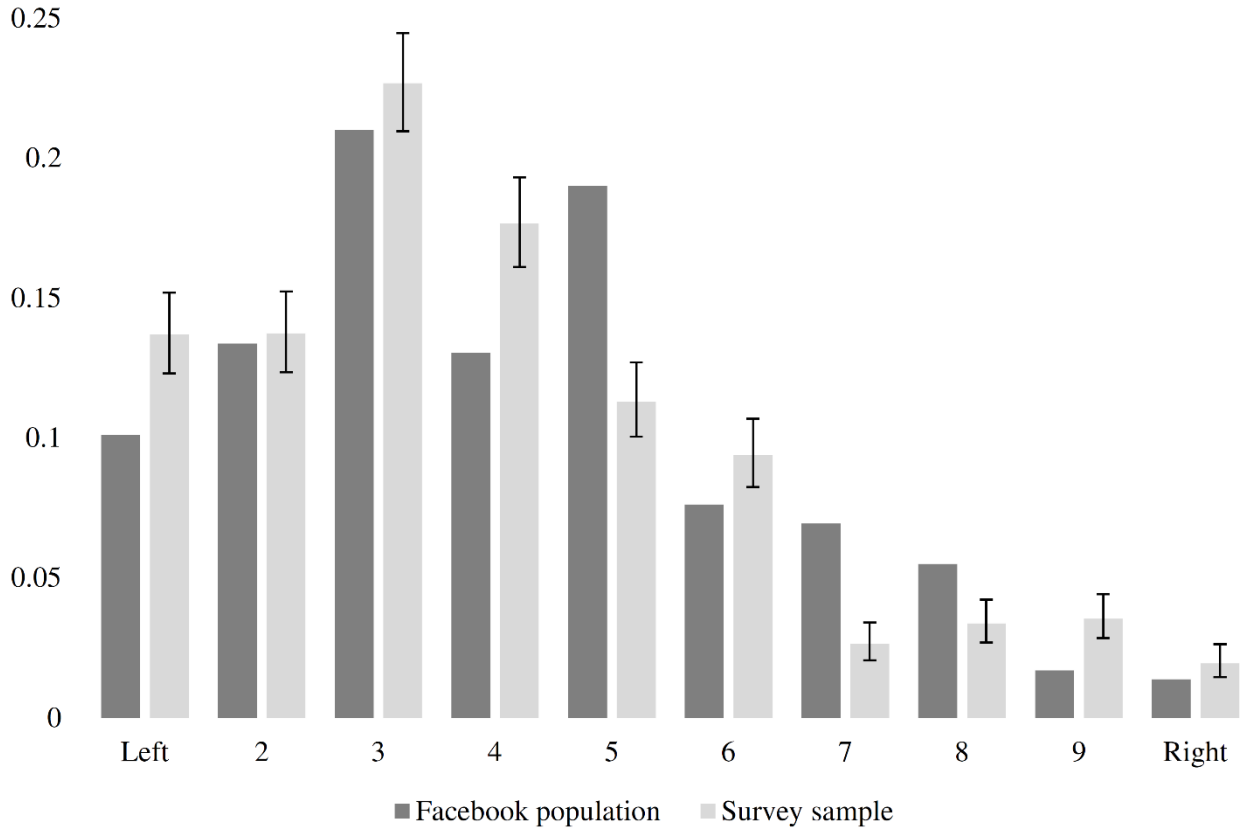

Figure A1 shows the distributions of the movement's Facebook population and the survey sample on a political left-right scale. The Facebook population's political attitude is measured by 28,981 individual profiles' likes of political parties (likes of either posts by the parties' profiles or the parties' affiliated politicians) which were active in the movement's Facebook groups in approximately the same period as the survey-data was collected. To enable comparison on the political left-right scale, the distribution of likes of political parties was transformed into a distribution on the left-right scale for each individual, which was then summed across the Facebook population. The transformation of the distribution of party-likes to a distribution of placement on the political left-right scale was achieved by calculating factors expressing the relationship between each party and the political left-right scale using data from the Danish sample of the European Value Study (EVS-DK) in 2017, comprising a total of 2,994 valid respondents. The EVS-DK 2017 survey included an item similar to the political scale presented above as well as items measuring political party preference. The inclusion of these items in the same survey enabled the calculation of the factors expressing the relative relationship between each party-category and the categories on the left-right scale which were used to transform the distribution of Facebook likes of political parties into a distribution on the left-right scale.

The means and variances of the movement Facebook population ($\bar{x}$=4.159; σ=2.205) and the sample ($\bar{x}$=3.899; σ=2.137) differ significantly according to z-, t- and F-tests. Thus, the survey sample is significantly more left-leaning and more homogenous than the Facebook population. However, the distance between the means is only 0.26 on the political 1-10 scale, which in substantial terms is a very modest difference, which can also be said for the difference in variance.

The gender distribution of the Facebook population is based on coding the names, which presents the challenge of some names not being exclusive to one or the other gender, and names in languages not known to the classifier (13.2%). Of the remaining 86.8 percent, 75.5 percent are women (in name at least). That the movement is made up mainly of women is reflected by the sample being 84.3 percent women. However, this is a significantly higher proportion than in the population, which implies that the sample under-represents men.

Table A1. Items included in focal variable, political protest

Activities	Political protest?		
	Yes		No
1. Posting on Facebook		×	
2. Liking and sharing Facebook posts		×	
3. Petitioning	×		
4. Collecting and donating materials			×
5. Collecting and donating money			×
6. Intercultural activity			×
7. Contact-person for refugees			×
8. Demonstrations and happenings	×		
9. Civil disobedience/direct action	×		
10. Legal assistance			×
11. Assisting newly arrived refugees			×
12. Illegal transportation of refugees	×		
13. Hiding refugees from authorities	×		
14. Econ. support to underground refugees	×		
15. Other support to underground refugees	×		
16. Refugees living in private home			×

Note: Item 1 and 2 concerning activity on Facebook cannot be allocated to any of the categories because the activity could be both political protest, as in posting political statements, and non-contentious, as in coordination donations to refugees.

Table A2. Random intercept multi-level Poisson regression model of participation in political protest (0–4)

Covariate	Coefficient	S.E.	P-value
Group level			
Contentious group style	3.606	1.307	0.006
Contentious framing	0.283	0.206	0.169
Individual level			
Personal network	0.016	0.035	0.653
Organizational network	0.003	0.141	0.984
Political civil society embed.	0.051	0.019	0.009
Other civil society embed.	-0.005	0.016	0.756
Active before September	0.266	0.067	0.000
History of activism	-0.126	0.031	0.000
History of refugee activism	0.176	0.035	0.000
Emotional response	0.290	0.049	0.000
Self-transcendent values	0.038	0.019	0.044
Self-enhancement values	-0.048	0.023	0.033
Political attitude	-0.190	0.041	0.000
Religion			
Non-believer		Reference	
Danish National Church	-0.267	0.084	0.001
Islam	0.013	0.231	0.956
Other	0.049	0.146	0.737
Degree of urbanization	0.073	0.031	0.018
Income	0.004	0.041	0.930
Occupation			
Full time		Reference	
Part time	-0.117	0.128	0.360
Self-employed	0.048	0.112	0.670
Student	0.151	0.168	0.370
Unemployed	-0.076	0.181	0.676
Early retirement	-0.015	0.177	0.932
Retired	-0.286	0.188	0.128
Other	-0.217	0.166	0.190
Worktime	-0.024	0.030	0.424
Highest level of education	0.035	0.036	0.330
Gender			
Female		Reference	
Male	0.041	0.093	0.660
Identify as neither	0.424	0.327	0.195
Children	0.002	0.076	0.983
Age	0.030	0.023	0.193
Age^2	0.000	0.000	0.292
Refugee	-0.035	0.194	0.855
Constant	-2.953	0.718	0.000
Random Effects			
Variance of constant	0.023	0.015	
Degrees of freedom		34	
Log-likelihood		-1354.973	

Note: *=p-value<0.05; **=p-value<0.01; ***=p-value<0.001. Total individual observations in all models=1,259. Total groups in all=75. Coefficients are unstandardized.